

Vanilla Wafer Crust

Makes one 9-inch pie crust

50 vanilla wafer cookies (to yield about 1½ cups crumbs)

5 tablespoons unsalted butter, melted and slightly cooled

⅛ teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon pure vanilla extract

This is a kid-pleasing crust that goes well with a variety of simple fillings.

1. Preheat the oven to 350 degrees.
2. Place the cookies in the workbowl of a food processor and process them until they are finely ground. Combine the crumbs, butter, salt, and vanilla in a medium-size mixing bowl and stir until the crumbs are moistened.
3. Press the mixture evenly across the bottom of a 9-inch pie plate and all the way up the sides of the pan, packing it tightly with your fingertips so it is even and compacted.
4. Bake the crust until it is golden and crisp, 6 to 8 minutes. Let it cool completely before filling it. (The crust may be wrapped in plastic wrap and frozen for up to 1 month.)

Vanilla Wafer and Sliced Almond Crust

Makes one 9-inch pie crust

40 vanilla wafer cookies (to yield about 1¼ cups crumbs)

5 tablespoons unsalted butter, melted and slightly cooled

⅛ teaspoon salt

1 teaspoon pure vanilla extract

¼ cup sliced almonds

Thinly sliced almonds don't need to be chopped in the food processor. Just add them directly to the cookie crumbs to give a plain vanilla crust a little more character.

1. Preheat the oven to 350 degrees.
2. Place the cookies in the workbowl of a food processor and process them until they are finely ground. Combine the crumbs, butter, salt, vanilla, and sliced almonds in a medium-size mixing bowl and stir until the crumb-and-nut mixture is moistened.
3. Press the mixture evenly across the bottom of a 9-inch pie plate and all the way up the sides of the pan, packing it tightly with your fingertips so it is even and compacted.
4. Bake the crust until it is golden and crisp, 6 to 8 minutes. Let it cool completely before filling it. (The crust may be wrapped in plastic wrap and frozen for up to 1 month.)